BASELINE FIRST

I ran the simplest possible RAG on the Mahabharata.

Here is what it exposed.

What I built: the bare minimum

- Fixed 1,000-character chunks
- A small open embedding model
- Top 5 passages by similarity
- An LLM writes a cited answer

No reranking. No query tricks. No framework.
Source: the Adi Parva, 237 sections.

Python · Gemini · sentence-transformers · NumPy

THE SURPRISE

0.81

correctness on 24 hand-labelled questions. It also refused every question the text cannot answer.

You do not always need a fancy strategy to get a reasonable start.

Small, hand-built set. Held-out check: 0.67.

Then I handed it the right passages.

Real retrieval **0.81**

Right passages supplied **0.96**

The model was not the problem. **Retrieval was.**

The answer text reached the model in only 67% of questions.

Correctness, working set, 24 questions

Know your corpus before you index it.

ONE PERSON, MANY NAMES

Arjuna = Partha = Dhananjaya

ONE NAME, MANY PEOPLE

Parikshit and Parikshita

STORIES INSIDE STORIES

A narrator retelling a lineage ten generations back

ONE LIFE, SCATTERED

Birth, family and deeds in different sections

Chunks cannot see any of this. The information has to be organised first: entity resolution, a knowledge graph, GraphRAG.

Retrieval was weaker than the score suggested.

I read the passages behind 12 graded answers:

> Right section, wrong paragraph.

> An irrelevant passage ranked #1.

> The key sentence cut off at a chunk boundary: `“And from Drupada wa…”`

A good score can hide a weak stage.

Calibrate the judge before you trust it.

1. An LLM judge scored the answers. I graded a sample blind and compared.
2. First round: **67%** agreement on correctness.
3. Causes: name aliases and spelling variants. Fixed one change at a time.
4. Re-tested on fresh answers, then froze the judge.

A judge you have not checked is just another guess.

Now I have a baseline to beat.

01 Smarter chunking

02 Hybrid search

03 Reranking

04 Query rewriting

05 GraphRAG for lineages

One change at a time. Every one measured against the same frozen judge.

NEXT

Improving it, one change at a time.

What would you try first?

I will share what moves the numbers, and what does not.